41

ONE THING I NEVER got comfortable with as president was riding in motorcades. Anytime we drove anywhere, we went in a convoy behind a police escort, and every time we crossed an intersection against the lights and I looked out and saw long lines of cars backed up on the side streets, I felt guilty because I knew how those people in the cars must feel having to wait like that.

How much our motorcade could disrupt traffic really became evident to me when we went to New York City in the middle of March, about two months after the inauguration. After flying from Washington to LaGuardia Airport, we helicoptered around the Statue of Liberty and saw the spectacular skyline of lower Manhattan, landed on a downtown helipad, and then sped through the city in the usual motorcade while the police closed off all the intersections. Ever since the presidential campaign, we'd had police escorts, but something was different about this trip I wasn't prepared for: The streets were lined with crowds of people all the way to the Waldorf Astoria, as if New York were having a holiday parade. Suddenly, I realized I was the parade. As we passed the crowds, people cheered and clapped and I wore out my arms waving back to them. It was an extremely humbling experience and that evening I wrote in my diary: "I keep thinking this can't continue and yet their warmth and affection seems so genuine I get a lump in my throat. *I pray constantly that I won't let them down.*"

In New York, I did some speech-making to campaign for passage of the economic recovery program. On the second night we went to see Mickey Rooney and Ann Miller, two old